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# Bob Knowlton (II)

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Knowlton never approached Dr. Jerrold to talk about what was worrying him. About six months after Fester's joining the photon lab, a meeting was scheduled in which the sponsors of the research were coming in to get some idea of the work and its progress. It was customary at these meetings for project heads to present the research being conducted in their groups. The members of each group were invited to other meetings which were held later in the day and open to all, but the special meetings were usually made up only of project heads, the head of the laboratory and the sponsors.

As the time for the special meeting approached, it seemed to Knowlton that he must avoid the presentation at all cost. His reasons for this were that he could not trust himself to present the ideas and work that Fester had advanced, because of his apprehension as to whether he could present them in sufficient detail and answer such questions about them as might be asked. On the other hand, he did not feel he could ignore these newer lines of work and present only the material which he had done or which had been started before Fester's arrival. He felt also that if Fester were at the meeting, it would not be beyond him at all to make blunt and undiplomatic comments - as was Fester's way - about Knowlton's presentation and reveal Knowlton's self-felt inadequacy. It also seemed quite clear that keeping Fester from attending the meeting would not be easy, even though he was not on the administrative level which was invited.

This is a revised version of the case adapted by Professor Maximilian B. Torres from the original "Bob Knowlton" case (HBS–Boston, Mass.: Harvard Business School Publishing, by Professors Alex Bavelas, A.H. Rubintein and H.A. Shepard). December 2019.
Cases are designed to promote class discussion rather than to illustrate effective or ineffective management of a given situation.
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